

1637

PHILOSOPHY OF DESCARTES

Published in the Netherlands in 1637, French thinker René Descartes' *Discourse on the Method* was a founding work of the Enlightenment. Arguing that reason was the key to knowledge, Descartes saw the thinking mind as separate from the body, which was simply a physical machine. His injunction to "doubt as far as possible of all things" encouraged scientific investigation of the world.



▷ René Descartes

1639 OTTOMANS REGAIN IRAQ

Murad IV, Ottoman emperor from 1623 to 1640, was a harsh and eccentric ruler. He was, however, successful in a war with Safavid Persia that lasted for most of his reign. Retaking Baghdad from the Safavids after a long siege in 1638, he made a peace the following year that left the Middle East divided along a line that still exists today – the current border between Iraq and Iran.



△ Sultan Murad IV receiving homage

“I think, therefore I am.”

RENÉ DESCARTES, INTRODUCTION TO DISCOURSE ON THE METHOD, 1637

1639

1639 At the Battle of the Downs, the Dutch navy destroys a Spanish fleet off the southern coast of England

1639

JAPAN REJECTS FOREIGN INFLUENCE

The influence of European traders and missionaries troubled Japanese society. In 1637–38, the Tokugawa shogunate was shaken by a major uprising in which Christian converts took part and responded by banning Christianity and limiting contact with foreigners. From then on the Dutch were the only Europeans allowed to trade with Japan, through the single port of Nagasaki.

▷ Catholics martyred in Nagasaki

